

Academic Writing & Assignment

Week 3: Lesson 4



THE LONDON SCHOOL
OF ECONOMICS AND
POLITICAL SCIENCE ■

Writing in your own voice



The need to provide evidence to support claims made in assignments means it is easy to focus on reporting other scholars' work at the expense of your own ideas or responses to what you read.

However, in most pieces of writing you will need to present your position on a topic or comment on what you describe. Your lecturer will want to know what you think based on what you have read, and what conclusions you draw as a result of your research.

You do this by developing your own academic 'voice' in which to speak to your reader.

How can you present your “voice”?



Techniques include:

- Effective use of topic sentences
- Using verbs to present your voice
- Adding evaluative adjectives to comment on sources.
- Using literature to support your claims



Effective use of topic sentences



Begin a paragraph with YOUR voice

Since social capital is differentially distributed, we need to understand the main factors that explain social capital inequality. As Newman (2011) suggests, social networks have a very different structure compared to random networks. According to the homophily hypothesis, “social interactions tend to take place among individuals with similar lifestyle and socioeconomic characteristics.” (Lin 2001, p. 39). In other words, networks of social ties tend to be homogeneous or assortative (Newman 2011) in terms of social attributes such as age, income, occupation, or education (Burt 1995). Moreover, the social segregation into clusters might be due to “systematic differences in the size of people’s social networks, across sociodemographic and socioeconomic groups” (Andersson et al. 2018, p. 103). For instance, Savage et al. (2013) show how individuals in the higher ladders of the British social structure have the highest values of social capital, compared to other socioeconomic groups.

Effective use of topic sentences



Avoid beginning a paragraph with a topic sentence that describes what someone else said e.g.

As Newman (2011) suggests, social networks have a very different structure compared to random networks. According to the homophily hypothesis, “social interactions tend to take place among individuals with similar lifestyle and socioeconomic characteristics.” (Lin 2001, p. 39). In other words, networks of social ties tend to be homogeneous or assortative (Newman 2011) in terms of social attributes such as age, income, occupation, or education (Burt 1995). Moreover, the social segregation into clusters might be due to “systematic differences in the size of people’s social networks, across sociodemographic and socioeconomic groups” (Andersson et al. 2018, p. 103). For instance, Savage et al. (2013) show how individuals in the higher ladders of the British social structure have the highest values of social capital, compared to other socioeconomic groups.

Using verbs to present your voice



Using verbs to present your voice



Newman (2011) suggests social networks have a very different structure compared to random networks.

This type of sentence is common in academic writing...

BUT

...it is descriptive not argumentative, evaluative or analytical.

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Using verbs to present your voice



Newman (2011) suggests social networks have a very different structure compared to random networks.

You could include your 'voice' in the sentences that follow e.g.

- *This means/illustrates/suggests...*
- *This is important/interesting/relevant because..*
- *This is flawed/problematic/unpersuasive because...*
- *As a result/Therefore/Consequently/Thus...*
- *In contrast/Conversely/On the other hand/However...*

Using verbs to present your voice



You could also change the sentence structure so that instead of using the verb to report what someone else said or thought...

Newman (2011) suggests social networks have a very different structure compared to random networks.

You use a reporting noun and save the verb to make your own comment...

The suggestion that social networks have a very different structure compared to random networks (Newman, 2011) is important because...

In this sentence, the verb is used for your voice – verbs are powerful!

Using verbs to present your voice



Similar ways of doing this include the below:

By suggesting that social networks have a very different structure compared to random networks, Newman (2011) makes a key contribution to research in this area.

Newman's suggestion that social networks have a very different structure compared to random networks (2011) is based on the research he conducted in Canada and may not be applicable to other contexts.

What are the problems?



- does not resolve the contradiction between X and Y
- fails to take into account/consider
- has been challenged because
- has been criticised by
- has several shortcomings
- is disputed by
- is inconsistent with
- is limited due to
- is questionable because
- offers no explanation for
- overlooks

What are the strengths?



- contributes to current research by
- is ground-breaking because
- is helpful when
- is a central component in
- is a key part of
- is instrumental in
- is related to

Where does it come from?



- arises from / out of
- derives from
- has its origins in
- is based on
- is formed by
- results from
- stems from

How does it relate to other ideas?



- provoked
- brought about
- precipitated
- resulted in
- sparked off
- lends credence to
- contributes to (the discussion on)

Why is it relevant?



- highlights (the need to)
- illustrates
- implies
- provides a basis for
- raises the question of
- suggests a/the need to



One more example



Reporting

Foucault **states /argues (that)** power is both dynamic and relational (1981).

Reporting and commenting

- **Foucault's argument that** power is both dynamic and relational (1981) **has been challenged by Smith's assertion that power is a phenomenon**
- **The argument that** power is both dynamic and relational (Foucault, 1981) **provides a basis for examining the legitimacy of sovereign power.**
- **By arguing that** power is both dynamic and relational, **Foucault (1981) raises questions of whether it is possible to possess sovereign power.**

Your turn



Write three sentences about a text you have read using this format:

Author (Year) + Reporting Verb +

For example:

Newman (2011) suggests social networks have a very different structure compared to random networks.

Your turn



Change the reporting verbs into a reporting noun/gerund and extend the sentences to add your voice.

- **The suggestion** that social networks have a very different structure compared to random networks (Newman, 2011) **is important because...**
- **Newman's suggestion** that social networks have a very different structure compared to random networks (2011) **is based on the research he conducted in Canada and may not be applicable to other contexts.**
- **By suggesting** that social networks have a very different structure compared to random networks, Newman (2011) **makes a key contribution to research in this area.**



Evaluative Adjectives



Carmichael and Wu (2003) provide an overview of personal information management (PIM).

This is purely descriptive.

I do not know what the writer thinks about the source.

So, we could add some comment ...

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Evaluative Adjectives



Carmichael and Wu (2003) provide a ***wide-ranging*** overview of personal information management (PIM).



1 Evaluative Adjectives



Friedman and Jones (2006) contains a discussion of the recent wave of labour unrest in China ***and their article really makes one think.***



1 Evaluative Adjectives



Friedman and Jones (2006) contains a ***thought-provoking*** discussion of the recent wave of labour unrest in China.



2 Evaluative Adjectives



Nahoulakian's (2005) model ***looks at productivity in a way that makes it seem simpler than it actually is and thus*** overlooks certain key factors.



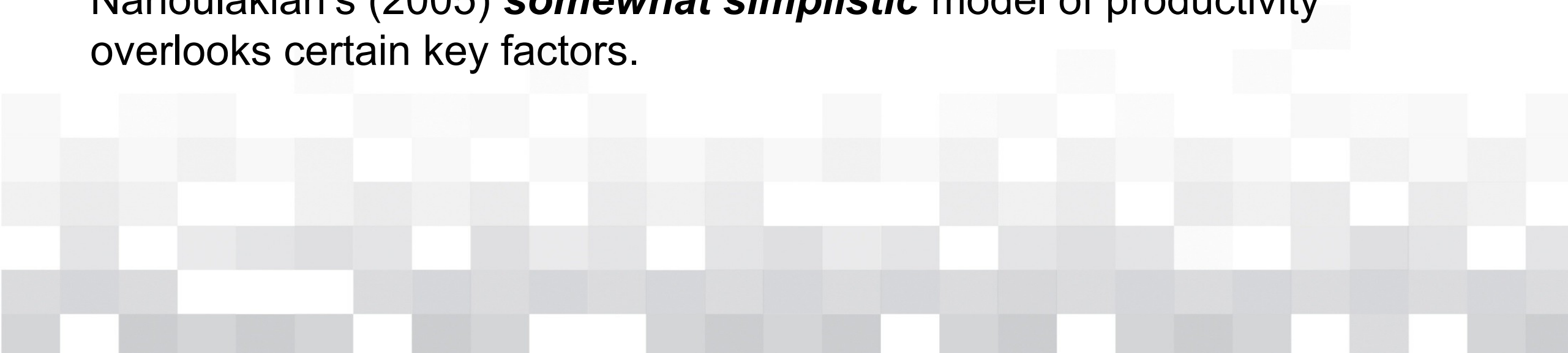
2 Evaluative Adjectives



Nahoulakian's (2005) ***simplistic*** model of productivity overlooks certain key factors.

Or

Nahoulakian's (2005) ***somewhat simplistic*** model of productivity overlooks certain key factors.



3 Evaluative Adjectives



Penhaligon and Gresswell (2009) provide an overview of personal information management (PIM) ***that includes everything that is necessary.***



3 Evaluative Adjectives



Penhaligon and Gresswell (2009) provide a ***comprehensive*** overview of personal information management (PIM).



4 Evaluative Adjectives



Ralfe (2003) conducted an analysis ***that was detailed and careful*** of the likely consequences of the proposed reforms.



4 Evaluative Adjectives



Ralfe (2003) conducted a ***thorough*** analysis of the likely consequences of the proposed reforms.

Rigorous



5 Evaluative Adjectives



Harris (2009) offers evidence to support the validity of the LMX model *that make you believe he is correct.*



5 Evaluative Adjectives



Harris (2009) offers ***convincing/persuasive*** evidence to support the validity of the LMX model.



6 Evaluative Adjectives



In her analysis of absenteeism, Davis uses a definition of ‘mental health’ ***that is limited in what it includes.***



6 Evaluative Adjectives



In her analysis of absenteeism, Davis uses a ***somewhat restricted/narrow*** definition of 'mental health'.



7 Evaluative Adjectives



In proposing the BNO model, Green and Bien (1996) made a contribution to our understanding of leadership ***that was different from what had been said before.***



7 Evaluative Adjectives



In proposing the BNO model, Green and Bien (1996) made an ***original/innovative/unique*** contribution to our understanding of leadership.



8 Evaluative Adjectives



Rother (2003) carried out an investigation ***that was done carefully and in an organized way*** into the role of HR managers in union disputes.



8 Evaluative Adjectives



Rother (2003) carried out a ***systematic*** investigation into the role of HR managers in union disputes.

SYSTEMIC VS SYSTEMATIC



Other evaluative adjectives



- a) Comprehensive
- b) Crucial
- c) Flawed
- d) Fundamental
- e) Ground-breaking
- f) Important

- g) Inadequate
- g) Limited
- g) Misguided
- g) Salient
- g) Seminal
- g) Significant



Positive



- a) Comprehensive
- b) Crucial
- c) Flawed
- d) Fundamental
- e) Ground-breaking
- f) Important

- g) Inadequate
- g) Limited
- g) Misguided
- g) Salient
- g) Seminal
- g) Significant

Negative



- a) Comprehensive
- b) Crucial
- c) Flawed
- d) Fundamental
- e) Ground-breaking
- f) Important

- g) Inadequate
- g) Limited
- g) Misguided
- g) Salient
- g) Seminal
- g) Significant

This vocabulary may be useful to inject comment into your sentences.
Decide which expressions are neutral, which positive & which negative:



- It is noteworthy that...
- It is arguable whether...
- This study has a direct bearing on...
- The authors' conclusions seem unfounded.
- Chen makes a cogent case to explain why...
- These results are borne out by Herman (2008) and Wang (2011).
- Richards (2014) omits to mention how...
- Martinez (1995) plays a pivotal role in demonstrating that...
- In claiming that...Smith (2009) fails to...
- Friedman's (2018) argument appears reasonable. However, on further reflection...
- A crucial stage has been reached...
- It is misguided to think that...
- In the current literature on...Rodrik (2018) is unique in drawing attention to...
- Current responses to...are proving to be inadequate.
- The author overlooks the fact that...
- This theory does not fully explain why...
- All the studies examined so far suffer from...

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Using literature to support your claims



What is the difference between these two sentences?

Milton and Jackson (2016) have identified three principle causes of poverty in the area.

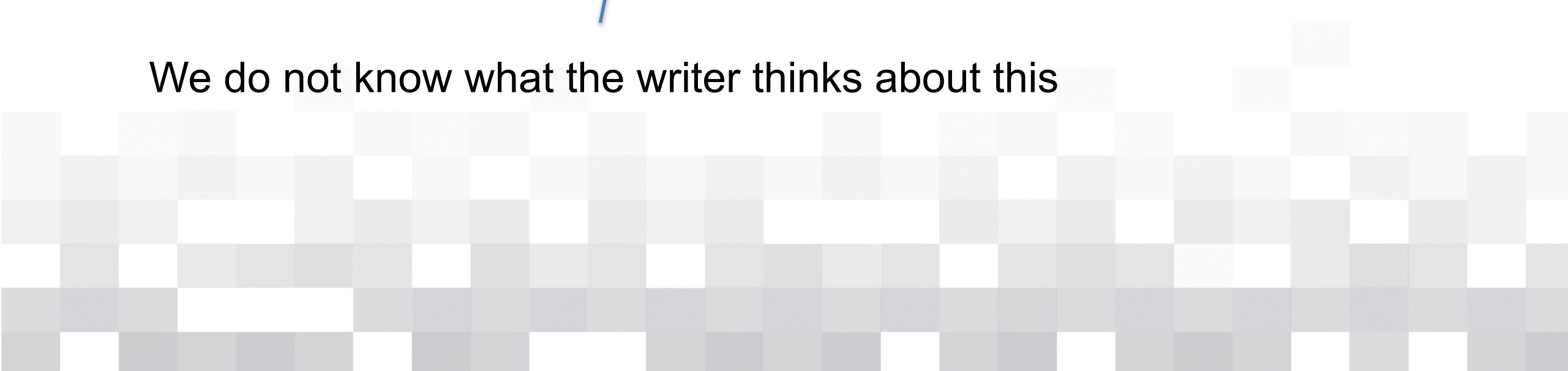
There are three principle causes of poverty in the area (Milton and Jackson, 2016).

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Milton and Jackson (2016) have identified three principle causes of poverty in the area.



We do not know what the writer thinks about this



There are three principle causes of poverty in the area (Milton and Jackson, 2016).

This is what the writer thinks

This is evidence to support what the writer thinks

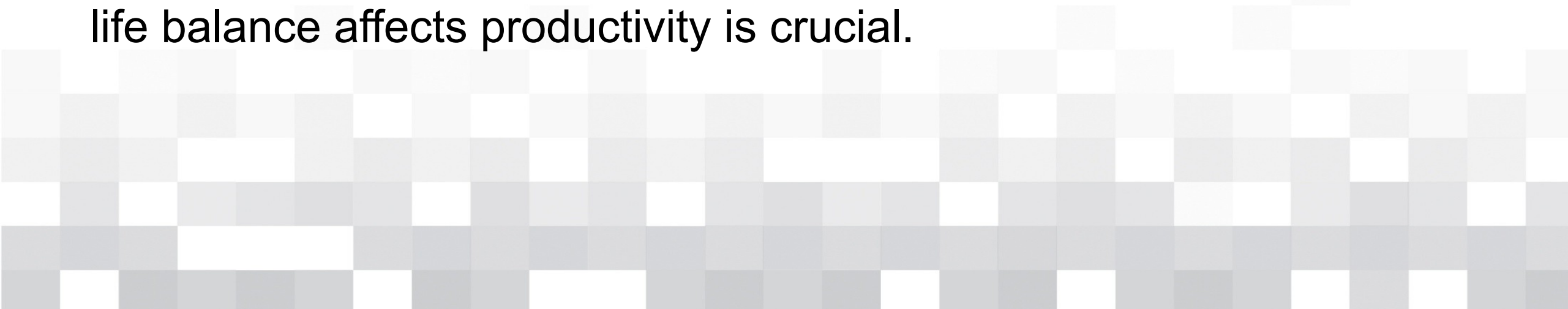
Dependent “As” clauses



What is the difference between these two sentences?

Beauregard (2004) has argued that understanding how home-work life balance affects productivity is crucial.

As Beauregard (2004) has argued, understanding how home-work life balance affects productivity is crucial.

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Beauregard (2004) has argued that understanding how home-work life balance affects productivity is crucial.

We do not know what the writer thinks about this



As Beauregard (2004) has argued, understanding how home-work life balance affects productivity is crucial.

This is what the writer thinks

This is evidence to support what the writer thinks

As – clauses – Common patterns.



As Haire (2008) points out,

Or

....., as Haire (2008) points out.

Or

As pointed out by Haire (2008),

As – clauses – Exercises.



The following sentences are purely descriptive. Rewrite them, using an “As” dependent clause to make a statement, so that your voice is heard.



Kerry et al. (2003) identified the key managerial styles found amongst head teachers as *Authoritative*, *Authoritarian*, *Permissive* and *Neglectful*.

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- ***As Kerry et al (2003) identified***, the key managerial styles amongst head teachers are...
- The key managerial styles amongst head teachers, ***as Kerry et al (2003) identified***, are...
- **As identified by Kerry et al (2003)**, the key managerial styles are...
- The key managerial styles are... (Kerry et al, 2003)

Wang and Copeland (2014) argue that companies must always retrain staff to effectively address particular security weaknesses.



- **As Wang and Copeland (2014) argue**, companies must always retrain staff to address particular security weaknesses effectively.
- Companies must always retrain staff to address particular security weaknesses effectively, **as Wang and Copeland (2014) argue**.
- **As argued by Wang and Copeland (2014)**, companies must always retrain staff to address particular security weaknesses effectively.
- Companies must always retrain staff to address particular security weaknesses effectively (Wang & Copeland, 2014)

Cooper (1990) and others have suggested that it is not always appropriate to apply findings from research into organisational behaviour to social media interactions.



- **Cooper (1990) and others have suggested** that it is not always appropriate to apply findings from research into organisational behaviour to social media interactions. **DESCRIPTIVE**
- **As Cooper (1990) and others have suggested**, it is not always appropriate to... **MAKING A CLAIM**
- It is not always appropriate to apply findings from research into organisational behaviour to social media interactions, **as Cooper (1990) and others have suggested**. **MAKING A CLAIM**
- **As suggested by Cooper (1990) and others**, it is not always appropriate to apply findings from research into organisational behaviour to social media interactions. **MAKING A CLAIM**
- It is not always appropriate to apply findings from research into organisational behaviour to social media interactions (Cooper, 1990). **MAKING A CLAIM**

Summary



Techniques to include your voice:

- Effective use of topic sentences
- Using verbs to present your voice
- Adding evaluative adjectives to comment on sources.
- Using literature to support your claims

Assignment Task for Week 3 – Essay Plan



On Moodle, you should upload an essay plan. The next few slides go through a process for doing this



Step One



Decide how many sections you want your essay to have & what each section will be about e.g.

- Introduction
- Section One: ...
- Section Two: ...
- Section Three: ...
- Conclusion

Step Two



Decide how many paragraphs you will have & write topic sentences for them

- Introduction
 - P6 TS
 - P7 TS
- Section One: ...
 - P1 Topic Sentence (TS)
 - P2 TS
- Section Two: ...
 - P3 TS
 - P4 TS
 - P5 TS
- Section Three: ...
 - Conclusion

Step Three



Provide some detail about what each paragraph will contain

For example:

P2 – Topic: Not all media can be treated as the same

Supporting ideas

- There are many types of media
- People use media in many different ways.
- We can't assume the media always has the same effects.

Make a rough plan now



- Spend 10 minutes writing a rough plan for your assignment.
- Explain your plan to your partner/group and ask for feedback.
- When you listen to other students' plans:
 - ask them to clarify anything that is unclear
 - ask them to explain the choices they have made about structure or the order of information
 - Give them suggestions for improving their plans